sovereignty sensitivities of a post-colonial order. Along the way, a broad compromise was struck where internal affairs were respected, while making exceptions in a few egregious cases. Even that was heavily tempered by strategic considerations; all departures from the supposed norm were not treated equally.

When it came to economics, transactionalism was much greater and societies were treated like black boxes. At a macro level, economic choices were not personal; it was just business. What was happening inside the box was not supposed to be our concern. But as globalization steadily promoted greater interpenetration of societies, this could no longer be dismissed with the same degree of complacency. We were letting in players into our lives who may believe, think and act very differently. It was no longer just a question of importing their products; in fact, they were now operating in our territory as well. And while this maybe physical in some respects, a digital age ensures that AI ranks foremost among our concerns.

Such an exposure naturally raised concerns about transparency and trust. It understandably bothers us if the restraints and firewalls that are our norm are not theirs. Not just that, the behavioural shifts in world affairs started to impact the global structure itself. In more sanguine times, we focussed mainly on efficiencies and competitiveness. However, as market shares and interdependence began to get strategically leveraged, the extent of our exposure also emerged as a national security concern. Such volumes did exist earlier; it was just that they were not manipulated in the same manner so prolifically before. There is no question that we have now slipped into a different culture of diplomacy, one with less inhibitions and greater coercion. Among the key developments of the last decade has been the weaponizing of the routine. It could be trade, tourism, connectivity or finance. As a result, everything needs to be hedged against now. Such anxieties have also fed into supply-chain concerns. The age of political agnosticism has effectively come to a close.

Ironically, the turn of events in Afghanistan could be interpreted as going in the opposite direction. For many, the real problem there was how intrusive the foreign presence in that country had become with the goal of nation-building particularly coming under criticism. It is a moot question whether the foreign presence in Afghanistan after the 9/11 attacks could have limited itself without adverse consequences. But even that is probably entering a false debate. The true challenge was not the ambition of the goals